

Mehmet Arif Demirtas

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Summary

I'm **Arif** (he/him)! In my research, I develop and evaluate systems to support instructors and students using generative AI models through human-centered design. My work focuses on computing education, specifically for students who are from fields other than Computer Science.

Education

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

PhD, Computer Science

Aug 2023 – May 2028

(expected)

- **Advisor:** Dr. Katie Cunningham

- **Research Interests:** Computer Science Education, Human-Computer Interaction

MS, Computer Science

Jan 2026

- **Thesis:** *Developing and evaluating domain models for programming skills using learning curve analysis*

Istanbul Technical University

BS, Computer Engineering

Sep 2018 - Jan 2023

- **Thesis:** *Automated Realistic Lip Sync Generation for Unconstrained Videos*

Selected Experience

AI/ML Research Intern

ACT Inc.

Iowa City, USA (Remote)

June 2025 – Aug 2025

- Led a human-centered design project for improving question authoring experience for subject matter experts creating multiple-choice reading comprehension questions for the ACT exam
- Conducted interviews to identify design opportunities for authoring tools with subject matter experts
- Designed and implemented a human-AI collaboration tool for question authors to utilize LLM-generated suggestions in early-stage ideation processes to improve user experience and productivity
- Evaluated the impact of the tool in a mixed-methods user study, to appear in **AIED 2026 [FP6]**

AI Research Engineer

Vitamu

London, UK (Remote)

April 2022 – June 2023

- Trained and deployed deep learning models for breast cancer detection and localization
- Managed development environments on AWS and Google Cloud in a startup environment

Selected Publications

* denotes equal contribution.

- [FP6] **M. A. Demirtas**, S. Nam, and G. Griffin. “Leveraging Human-AI Collaboration for a Passage-Based Question Authoring Tool”. In: *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence in Education*. Springer Nature Switzerland. 2026.
- [FP5] **M. A. Demirtas**, C. Zheng, and K. Cunningham. “Teaching Authentic Programming Applications to Novices: Purpose-first Tutorials in a General Education Computing Course”. In: *Proceedings of the 57th ACM Technical Symposium on Computer Science Education V.1*. New York, NY, USA: Association for Computing Machinery, 2026, pp. 274–280.
- [FP4] Y. Jain*, **M. A. Demirtas***, and K. Cunningham. “PLAID: Supporting Computing Instructors to Identify Domain-Specific Programming Plans at Scale”. In: *Proceedings of the 2025 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*. 2025, pp. 1–21.

- [FP3] **M. A. Demirtaş**, C. Zheng, M. Fowler, and K. Cunningham. “Generating Planning Feedback for Open-Ended Programming Exercises with LLMs”. In: *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence in Education*. Springer Nature Switzerland. 2025, pp. 33–48.
- [FP2] **M. A. Demirtaş**, M. Fowler, and K. Cunningham. “Reexamining Learning Curve Analysis in Programming Education: The Value of Many Small Problems”. In: *Proceedings of the 17th International Conference on Educational Data Mining*. International Educational Data Mining Society. 2024, pp. 53–67.
- [FP1] **M. A. Demirtaş**, M. Fowler, N. Hu, and K. Cunningham. “Validating, Refining, and Identifying Programming Plans Using Learning Curve Analysis on Code Writing Data”. In: *Proceedings of the 2024 ACM Conference on International Computing Education Research-Volume 1*. 2024, pp. 263–279.

Teaching

- Lead Teaching Assistant, **Modeling and Learning in Data Science**, *UIUC* *Spring 2026*
 Teaching Assistant, **Modeling and Learning in Data Science**, *UIUC* *Fall 2025*
- Leading hour-long discussion sections for CS307 - Modeling and Learning in Data Science with Dr. David Dalpiaz (Fall 2025) and Dr. Pablo Robles Granda and Dr. Dan Gonzalez (Spring 2026)
 - Preparing and teaching lectures on ML fundamentals and applications with Scikit-Learn for over 100 students
- Instructor / Facilitator, **Machine Learning Foundations**, *Break Through Tech* *Summer 2026*
 Course Support, **Machine Learning Foundations**, *Break Through Tech* *Summer 2025*
- Supported the small group discussions in the lectures for the 9-week ML Foundations course with 52 students
 - Provided just-in-time instruction for weekly assignments
- Lecturer, **Introduction to Python**, *ITU ACM Student Chapter* *Fall 2022*
- Held introductory Python lectures and supervised hands-on tutorial sessions for more than 100 students
- Guide & Mentor, **Deep Learning Study Group**, *inzva.com* *Oct 2021 - Nov 2022*
- Gave lectures on object detection, face recognition, and neural style transfer to more than 100 students as part of the Google Developers ML Bootcamp and Deep Learning Study Group at inzva hackerspace

Undergraduate Mentorship

Claire Zheng, *Fall 2024 - Spring 2026*
 Yoshee Jain, *Spring 2024 - Fall 2024*
 Nicole Hu, *Spring 2024*

Honors & Awards

Future Leaders of AI, ACM AI Summit (\$1250), *2026*.
Doctoral Consortium Travel Funding, EDM 2024 (\$2500), *2024*.

Grants

- Building a community of practice to support programming education across engineering departments*. Strategic Instructional Innovations Program, The Grainger College of Engineering (\$6500). *2026*.
- **PIs:** Katie Cunningham, Ali Ansari, Bryan K Clark, Christopher Tessum, Elizabeth Wickes, Max Fowler, **Mehmet Arif Demirtaş**.
 - **Role:** Co-author of proposal and corresponding co-PI for research activities.

Service

- Panel Moderator**, SIGCSE Virtual 2024 *December 2024*
- *Challenges and Solutions for Teaching Decomposition and Planning Skills in CS1* with Dr. Eliane S Wiese, James Finnie-Ansley, Dr. Rodrigo Duran, Dr. Katie Cunningham
- Reviewer:** SIGCSE TS 2027-2026-2025, CHI 2025, SIGCSE Virtual 2024, Computer Science Education
- Student Research Competition Judge:** ISUR Research Expo 2026